It's a Baby

By Cara Restaino

INTRODUCTION

Can a baby born in the worst of situations actually be a blessing that provides unity? What if a family that appears put-together is actually hurting and a traumatic incident is exactly what they need to overcome it? Cara Restaino explores these questions by telling of the opportunities she had in her youth to learn from her sister's mistakes. It's a Baby, by Cara Restaino.

This is intended to be performed by one woman. She plays all characters. Distinctions are made through varying focal points, shifting voices, and adjusting postures. Other methods of character portrayal are open to interpretation .

CARA: The Virgin Mary. The holiest woman in the Catholic religion. *[Pause.]* One day an angel messenger came to Mary and told her that she was going to have the son of God. *Surprise*, it's a *baby!* A pretty important baby … Then, two thousand years later, there is Stephanie. Stephanie Restaino, my sister. Three years ago, my sister thought she had a stomach virus. *[Pause.]* My sister had a baby. She didn't know she was pregnant until about twenty minutes before she had the baby. This, however, was *NOT* a virgin birth and there was no messenger. *[Pause.]*

You see, you have to understand my sister. She is different, unlike any person I have ever known.

When she was little, my sister had trouble spelling. She was a little … slow … concepts didn't come as fast to her as they did to other kids or to me, for that matter. I was a *fast* learner. But not Stef. My mother took matters into her own hands had been trying to get Stephanie to learn how to spell three letter words and then, one day, while in the car, my sister made an announcement. "I can spell a word!" My mother perked up, could it be there has been some sort of recognition? Could she have mastered phonics?

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"Sex! S-E-X! Sex! SEX!" My mother swallowed hard. My eyeballs nearly fell out of my head.

[Long pause.]

She could spell, we realized. Though, in addition to being a little on the slow side, my sister had a curious interest in the subject.

This incident ... spelling *sex* in the car ... began a sort of tradition with my sister that remains true today. No, no, we weren't shocked.

School, in general, was hard for her. She struggled with keeping up, but she didn't let that hold her back. What she lacked in intellect she made up in sheer originality, making her mark in other ways. She had spiky hair and lime green eye shadow. She went by the name "Donut"-she was "round and sweet."

While other kids applied to Yale, Harvard, and, well, Rutgers, my sister decided to follow in my mother's footsteps and become a chef. She applied to the Culinary Institute of America and got in.

Not long after my sister arrived at the CIA, she fell in love with Jason. *[Pause.]* Jason was a triple threat. By the time I got to know him, he had a criminal record for armed robbery, which led him to a year stint at Riker's, a child with another girl, and a life threatening blood disorder. Although she had a good heart, my sister had *bad* judgment.

And, at the time they met, my sister Stephanie was still Donut ... very round ... and sweet. And Jason wasn't interested in the girl who looked like she *eaten* a bakery. They were just friends.

One weekend she came home and announced she was staying. And then, she began losing weight, fast. By that time, my parents opened the restaurant and she was working all the time. She was down over one hundred pounds. And, by the time Jason got out of the big house, my sister wasn't as big as a house anymore. She looked amazing, and I am sure that when he saw her for the first time, he was more than surprised.

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Needless to say, love blossomed. They were with each other night and day. He lived in Queens, so my sister was out there almost every weekend. "Be careful!" my mother would yell to her. "Watch what you're doing!" she would call. She wasn't talking about driving either. Even if my sister could *spell sex*, didn't mean she knew how to be responsible *with* sex.

In July of that same year, we took a family trip, Jason included, to Cancun. Well, my sister and Jason were sick the entire week. They threw up from one side of Mexico to the other. After we got back, every so often my sister would be sick again- throwing up, stomachaches, etc.

And by December she was looking awful. She had these dark circles under her eyes and her hair was getting curly, which was strange because she had this thick poker-straight hair ever since she was a kid.

Every once in a while I'd catch her throwing up in the bathroom and she would swear that her stomach was just upset. She'd say, "I don't know ... ever since Mexico I haven't been right. Maybe I have a parasite or something." And then she'd go outside for cigarette. She's a tough girl. She looks tough, she acts tough, she talks tough. I believed her. But the fact of the matter was that she looked like shit.

Months went by like this, and by January 2003, she was in a bad state. She was working twelve-hour days and her skin had turned the color of a cold, fried veal cutlet. She was gray. I told her to stop smoking, to stop the late nights out drinking with her friends and actually go to bed early, but she ignored me. And on the Saturday before the most insane week of our lives, she worked all day. She made two cheesecakes during the afternoon, worked the line, and spun pies in between. Her friends came in around nine o'clock and she cooked dinner for them too. By the time she sat down she looked awful. But she helped them polish off two bottles of wine and several packs of cigarettes before she and Jason went home.

The next day, around four in the afternoon, my mom told her, "Go home. You look

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like shit. It's just Monday night, I can handle it. If you don't feel better, go over to the Immediate Care Center or something. .. but call me."

Everything seemed OK until around eight when Jason called to say that they were headed to the Immediate Care Center because she was really in pain. "This Mexico thing really got her," he had said. "Alright, alright. Just call us when you finish."

About an hour later they called to say that they were on their way to the hospital. When she and Jason walked into the ER, my sister gave her name.

"I'm Stephanie Restaino. I have a.... " But before she could finish, the nurse ushered her in and Jason took a seat in the waiting room.

She was poked and prodded by several nurses and doctors. Then, finally, the doctor said, *"OK,* we're either going to take you to Labor and Delivery or surgery." "Labor and Delivery? For what?" "Well, you're having a *baby."*

"No, I'm Stephanie Restaino. I have a stomach virus."

And instantly, she was surrounded by six doctors and two crash carts and a lot of silence. They knew she was pregnant. They knew *she* didn't know she was pregnant. And as they examined her, they could hear a heartbeat, but couldn't find the baby. My sister, as I said, was very thin. When they laid her on the table, her stomach was concave. And as the doctor listened for a heartbeat. They weren't sure, but toxins were released in her blood flow, lethal toxins that could kill both her and the baby if the situation wasn't handled fast.

In the meantime, a nurse was sent to retrieve Jason, who still had his black leather coat on as he sat watching *Fear Factor.*

"Are you Jason? Stephanie's boyfriend?"

"Yeah."

"Come with me, please."

She led him to the emergency room, where my sister was waiting. The nurse closed the curtain and my sister had to tell him what was going on.

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"Jay, I'm having a baby." "You're pregnant?"

"No, I'm having a baby ... *now.*" And before she could say anything else, the curtain flew open and the nurses tore off her clothes and shoved them into an elevator.

They told her that she would have the baby in about twenty minutes.

"Wait! I have to call my mom! She has to be here!'!"

She had no drugs ... a completely natural birth, but it wasn't easy. The baby was actually situated up in her rib cage, which accounted for the lack of a belly. The doctors had to actually work her down-she didn't want to budge!

Nevertheless, shortly before midnight on Monday,January 13, 2003, at 5 pounds, the baby was born. A girl. *[Pause.]*

Oh! But that's not the end of the story.

My parent's the phone rang.

"Yeah, Stef." My dad had answered it. "Mommy? Yeah, she's here. Hold on." *[Pause.].*

"Stef? Stef! Where are you? Are you still at the hospital?"

"Yeah, Mom, I'm at the hospital."

"Did they admit you?"

"Yeah, Mom ... Mom, listen to me. Are you awake?" "Yeah, Stef. I'm awake. What's going on?"

"Mom ... I had a baby."

"What?"

"I had a baby ... it's OK ... it's a girl."

Dead air. Silence.

"Mom? Mom, you've got to come up here."

"OK, OK. We'll be there in a little bit."

"Mom, I'm scared."

"I know ... " *[Pause.]*

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"No, I'm scared that Daddy is going to kill Jason." *[Pause.]*

"I know." She hung up the phone and turned to my father. "Somebody wanna tell me what is going on?"

My mother was trying to find the words to convey this information to this man in the most direct way possible.

So my mom looked at him and said, *[Pause.]* "Stefanie just birthed a baby."

In an instant my father was standing. "I can't! I won't! I'll kill her! I'll kill *him!*"

And my mother, now completely out of character, took charge of the situation. *"Listen!* Listen to me very carefully. She is *your* daughter. This is *her* baby. She's not the first. She won't be the last. It's 2003. Get over it." And she stormed out of the room.

And my father called after her, "Where are you going?"

"I'm going to wake Cara."

Now, let's go back to me. Remember me? I was *so* tired. I didn't go out that night so that I could catch up on some much needed sleep. Yeah, so me. I was all *schnuggly-wuggly* in my bed having good dreams ... pleasant dreams where my door doesn't fly open to reveal my mother is standing in the doorway ... yelling ... loudly ...

"Cara! CARA! Wake up!" "What ... what's the matter?"

"Get up! Your sister is in the hospital."

"The hospital? Is she OK?"

"Fine. *[Pause.]* She had a baby. It's a girl." And then she just turned around and walked out of the room.

A baby?!? What the hell was she talking about-a *baby?* I fumbled for my glasses and went into my parents' room. My father was sitting at the edge of the bed staring at the wall.

"Wait, I don't understand. She had a *baby?"*

"A baby. Yes, a baby. She had a baby. Now hold this, I need to call your uncle. Your father is going to kill Jason."

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I stood there is disbelief. I didn't know what to do next. I looked at my father.

"Dad? ... Dad? ... DAD! You gotta snap out of this. It's going to be OK. Everything is going to be OK." *[Long pause.]*

He didn't look up. He didn't even blink. He just stared at that wall.

My father *was* going to kill Jason. Yes, I believe that wholeheartedly. As he stared at that wall he thought about all the horrible, torturous things he would do to him. I could see his fury being projected onto the wall ... he nearly burned a whole right through it.

My mother wiped her mouth and walked over to my father. "You. Get up and get dressed. We have to get to that hospital and see our granddaughter."

He didn't look up. He just stood and grabbed his clothes.

We piled in our cars and made our way to see Stephanie. No one in the car uttered a single word ... not a sound. But *silently, feverishly* we prayed for… Jason.

We literally ran into the hospital and my mother got to the nurses' station.

[Out of breath.] "I'm Josephine Restaino. Stephanie's mom." The nurse smiled at her. "Your daughter is on the 3rd floor."

As we got in the elevator, we could feel the tension. And then my father began shaking his head. "They're on the 3rd floor." "Yeah."

"Well, that's not good. I was going to throw Jason out the window. The third floor won't kill him. He'll break his arms and then I'll really have to support him."

Ah, humor. Lighthearted humor. There was hope!

Once we got off the elevator, Jason was waiting. When he saw us, he completely broke down. We all did. Who could believe this was happening? It was surreal. My father was the first one to go up to him. Jason could barely lift his head. And then he extended his hand. But my father grabbed him. And he hugged him and we all finally felt like we could breathe.

He told us the whole story. How my sister almost died. How the baby almost died. How we were experiencing a miracle.

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He led us to my sister, who was lying in bed with a blanket over her ... over all of her ... even her face. My mother stood next to the bed.

"It's OK." And then we all cried some more.

They told us that they had chosen to name the baby Angelina. "Awww ... ," I said, "Little angel."

Angelina had no health problems despite the fact that my cigarette-smoking, wine-drinking, pill-popping sister went through what the doctors say was nine full months of pregnancy without a single prenatal vitamin, let alone doctor's visit. And Angelina is the smartest kid I have ever seen, regardless of her parents' inadequacies. I guess two negatives do make a positive.

It's been 3 years. I should catch you up on what's gone on. My niece is fine. She's a lot like my sister ... reeking havoc. But she's smart, like me ... she can spell *dog.*

Jason left almost a year ago. Turns out he was having an affair with my sister's best friend. Shit happens. He gave her the best thing he ever could have ... Angelina. My mother, who swore up and down that she would never be a Nana, is indeed Nana.

And in the most interesting turn of events, my sister has become something I never thought she could be. She has handled motherhood with a sense of wisdom that overshadows anything that has happened in the past. She is a brilliant mother who loves her daughter with that innate compassion that they say girls are born with. She has it. I always knew that I could outscore my sister on any test. I could write better, I could add better, I could *certainly* spell better. But I don't know if I'll ever be half the mother that she is.

And my dad, my dad and Angelina are inseparable. In the hardest, most trying times I think that my father looks at Angelina and knows that somehow she was sent to save him.

And me, I've been given a rare gift. I have been able to travel back in time to see my mother and father as young parents-how they were with me when I was a baby. The years melt away when they are around Angelina and I can see them with a sort of

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immortality that defies fact that time marches on. *[Pause.]*

I try to rationalize things. Why this happened. Why she came and why she came in the way she did. How what should be a beautiful blessed thing can turn into a tragedy. And how it could have been a tragedy for us. And beyond some deep, philosophical message, I've only this. You needed a messenger. I'm not sure what would have happened if my sister didn't make it to the hospital. If we didn't get that crazy phone call that changed everything. Nothing has been the same since ... nothing has been the same, but it has all been for the better. *[Pause.]*

The Virgin Mary gave us Jesus Christ ... my sister gave us Angelina ... not quite the same thing, and yet she has saved us in a way. And if you would, *hear* this story. Listen to the message, from me, your less than angelic messenger. We can get ourselves into some difficult situations. But everything happens for a reason.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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